

# Giving and Receiving Feedback with EQ

*Applying emotional intelligence — self-awareness, self-management, empathy, and relationship management — to both sides of a feedback conversation.*

This guide focuses on the emotional dimension of feedback specifically. For structuring a formal performance review conversation, see the companion Performance Conversation Guide; for a fuller treatment of receiving feedback as a coachee, see the companion Feedback for Coachees Guide — this resource condenses that side to keep the focus on giving.

## 1. Emotional Preparation Guide

Before the words of feedback matter, your own emotional state matters — it shapes tone, timing, and whether the conversation is really about them or, quietly, about you.

### Self-Awareness Check

- What am I actually feeling right now — frustration, anxiety, disappointment, something else?
- Is any of this feeling left over from something unrelated (a bad day, a different frustration) rather than this specific issue?
- Am I coming from a genuine wish to help this person improve, or do I mostly want to vent or be right?

### Self-Management Before You Begin

- If you're currently activated (angry, anxious), wait until you're regulated enough to speak calmly — delayed feedback delivered well beats immediate feedback delivered poorly
- Get clear on the specific behavior and impact beforehand, so the conversation doesn't drift into vague impressions once emotion is in the room
- Choose a time and setting that gives the conversation a real chance — not right before a meeting they're rushing to, not in front of others

### Pre-Conversation Checklist

| Item                                                                  | Check |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|-------|
| I can state the specific behavior, not just a general impression      |       |
| I can state the actual impact, concretely                             |       |
| I'm regulated enough to stay calm if they react defensively           |       |
| I've picked a reasonable time and private setting                     |       |
| I genuinely want this conversation to help them, not just to be heard |       |

## 2. Empathic Delivery Framework

Empathy here doesn't mean softening the feedback until it disappears — it means genuinely considering their likely experience of hearing it, and adjusting your approach, not your content, accordingly.

### Before You Speak: Perspective-Taking

- What might this look like from their side — are they even aware this is an issue?
- What might they be dealing with that I don't know about?
- How is this feedback likely to land given our history and their current situation?

### The Delivery Structure

| Step                         | What It Sounds Like                                                                              |
|------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Lead with genuine care       | "I want to talk about something because I think it matters for how this goes for you."           |
| Specific behavior and impact | "In yesterday's client call, you spoke over Priya twice, and I noticed her go quiet after that." |
| Invite their perspective     | "What's your take on how that call went?"                                                        |
| Collaborative next step      | "What would help you catch that in the moment next time?"                                        |

### Reading and Adjusting in Real Time

- If they go quiet or withdraw, slow down and check in directly: "How are you doing with this so far?"
- If they become defensive, resist matching that energy — stay calm and curious rather than repeating your point more forcefully
- If they seem to already know and are relieved it's being named, you can move faster to the collaborative step

### 3. Receiving Feedback Techniques

A condensed EQ-focused summary — see the companion Feedback for Coachees Guide for the full reception framework, emotional response guide, and processing techniques.

- Notice your emotional reaction without acting on it immediately — defensiveness is a normal signal, not a verdict on the feedback's accuracy
- Separate the feedback itself from your feelings about receiving it — both are real, but they're not the same thing
- Ask a genuine clarifying question before responding, rather than immediately agreeing or defending
- Thank the person for raising it, even when it stings — this keeps the relationship open for future honesty

## 4. Follow-Up Conversation Guide

A feedback conversation that ends with no follow-up often quietly fades, whether or not it actually landed. Checking in afterward is where real change either gets reinforced or, if it isn't happening, gets addressed before it becomes a pattern.

### When to Follow Up

- A few days to a week after the original conversation — enough time for a real attempt at change, not so long that momentum is lost
- Sooner, if you notice the same behavior recurring almost immediately

### How to Open It

- *"I wanted to check in about our conversation last week — how has it been sitting with you?"*
- *"I've noticed [specific change] since we talked — how has that felt from your side?"*

### Reading Whether It Actually Landed

- Genuine engagement sounds like specific examples of what they tried, not just "yeah, it's fine"
- If their account doesn't match what you've actually observed, name the gap gently rather than letting it pass unaddressed
- If the first approach clearly didn't work, that's information to adjust your approach, not evidence to repeat it more forcefully